6

Darkness. The good kind, the kind that offered still and calm and comfort. He wasn't anywhere in particular–no images or even awareness bothered his rest–he just *was*. Floating. He breathed into it, the whole of his form sunk down into the cot. Faintly, he heard the air cyclers kick on, a low resonance that further deepened his relaxation.

Finally, reluctantly, he came to. He had a body, he realized, limbs that lay heavy. He wondered if he could move them–did they move, did he have the strength?–and after considering it for a moment, tested his limits. He rolled over. He sighed: that's right…he had a body. Yawning, he brought his left hand to his face and massaged his eye with a palm.

Where was he? His senses reached out in some indiscriminate ability to decode the layout of the room, the position of the door from his cot. Eyes closed, he could tell he was backed up to a wall, the doorway ahead of him by probably only a few paces. The sound of the air scrubbers came from above.

Still in a half sleep, he frowned. The room was wrong, all of it, save for his back to a bulkhead–a tiny bit of reassurance and security on an otherwise insidious vessel. Had he fallen asleep somewhere else? His ear craned to listen for the shuffle of feet outside the storage room, the clatter of work already starting early in the day cycle. Shrike ran a tight ship–no one slacked on his watch. A military discipline maintained order.

Military, Han recollected. Of course. Not his makeshift bunkroom in the back cargo hold of the *Trader's Luck*, but his bunk on the Praetor. He listened, expecting the breathing of his squadmates beneath him, the rustle of sheets, the knocking and creaking of the old ship as she teetered and tottered her way through patrol. None of that came to him. On the Destroyer, then?

His chest twisted, urging him to wake, to make sense of the inconsistencies and investigate. With a sharp inhale, he picked his

head up. Despite the dark, he read the space: alone, in a bunk, the room small but private, the threshold in the corner opposite him.

He sighed, resigned. The 'Suub. His bunk. His ship. Grumbling, he readjusted himself and flipped over, away from the doorway. He hated when he did this…forgot where he was. Forgot the timeline.

Though he resettled, though he managed to keep his mind blank and shut his eyes and slow his breathing again, he lay there for a few minutes in a quiet that would not slip back into sleep. He sighed, purposefully big and heaving, hoping that with his exhale would go whatever was holding him in consciousness. He shut his eyes slightly tighter, then released his muscles, first squeezing then relaxing, starting at his feet and calves and letting the motion ripple up his body. He rarely got as high as his abdomen and chest before he sunk down.

He was on his fourth attempt to move around his jaw when he decidedly gave up. He threw himself onto his back with a huff, the bristle of irritation contorting his mouth. Was he still so damn upset, he wondered, then realized he couldn't grasp at what.

What time was it anyway? His arm stretched to just the right length to let his fingers catch the corner of the bedside table. He felt his way across the surface until he caught the familiar curve of his watch. In darkness, his thumbs traced the face, feeling for the tactile readout of the remaining flight time. Automatically, he checked for a high value–a 5 or 6–but found no purchase. Doubting, he fingered for a higher number, but at finding nothing and doubting even more, he searched lower. Not 3. Not 2.

He sat bolt upright as his thumb brushed past the 1. His hand shot out to flick on half the room's lights, and wincing into the brightness, he investigated the timepiece's face. He gawked to read it, his eyes tracing it a few times to be sure: less than an hour to go.

He cocked his head, staring off into the corner. Really? He never knocked out like that, especially on a trip. Skeptical, he checked the readout on the wall console beside his bed. The number clicked

down, roughly reading about thirty minutes until deceleration. He'd managed to come to just before the alarm sounded.

He laid his head back against the bulkhead. Okay, he admitted: this trip had tired him more than he thought. He probably hadn't had a good night's sleep since…well… He couldn't recall.

He ran a hand over his face, that hazy feeling slipping over him again. He'd get up, he reasoned faintly…when he had to. His ears crackled and popped as he yawned, and he ran a hand through his hair and roughed it, trying to wake himself up further. He tried to readjust, attempting to prop himself up on an elbow to scoot more upright, but a sudden seizing in his ribcage stopped him. He yelped as a hand wrapped around the area to protectively clutch. Not piercing pain, he discerned, and no blood. A wide, aching pain, like blunt force, like he'd knocked into something. Or had been thrown.

He winced as he remembered. Carefully, he dragged his fingertips across the welt on his forehead, igniting a pain that *was* sharp, though also radiated across the rest of his skull. The swelling had gone down, he guessed as he gently patted the area. He probably had a multicolored badge across his forehead, now that bruising had set in. He might have bacta laying around somewhere. Reflexively, he looked in the direction of the 'fresher, past the threshold, then paused as the image of the Wookiee looming in his doorway swam into his mind's eye again. The hair standing on end, the eyes wild, the claws stretched out toward him. He'd been too distracted to make sense of it at the time, but Chewie's growl had vibrated through his chest. He didn't know they could get that loud. That angry.

No, some part of him corrected. He had seen that before, that primal rage that made Wookiees so dangerous. So feared. He'd been near unconscious, wildly ill. So much of the interaction had been an indiscernible swirl of part reality, part dreamworld, but he could recall at some point, picking his head up enough to see the towering figure of a Wookiee, her voice more growl and bark than her usual susurrous tone, backing Shrike up into the doorway. Han couldn't see him past Dewlanna's height, but he could hear Shrike trying to minimize her

concerns in his typical flippant style. A little too much grip in his voice, though, as he tried to play off how sick the boy was. Dewlanna wasn't having it. She could be placid…until she wasn't.

He sank into the bunk slightly to think of her. The way she tenderly grumbled at him, the cooing and the pets she freely gave. The little tittering laugh she did when she'd mess up his hair against his wishes, and the care with which she would fix it. The chiding, too, when that was necessary, which was pretty often. How glossy she kept her coat, diligently combing and trimming it, scrupulous about keeping any hair out of the dishes she prepared. The smell of her musk. Not like the sharp tang of Chewie, though he barely noticed it anymore, but softer. Warmer.

The air cyclers shut off with that characteristic choking sound like something had been broken. Something probably *was* broken, he assessed, though he sat too far away from apathy or annoyance, too insulated, for it to touch him. It would probably break at some point, he continued, another problem in yet another system.

He chewed at his lips, waiting for the inevitable siren from the cockpit to force him up, when his ears caught another sound. He listened for a beat, trying to place it, but even after straining, couldn't register it as anything familiar. It wasn't mechanical–too irregular, too guttural.

His head tilted to try again. His brain unscrambled the noise: it was voices, he realized. Chewie's, coming in stops and starts. He squinted in confusion. Chewie wasn't given to making noise. Dewlanna had constantly murmured and hummed and sang and talked to herself, but Chewie had frequently proven to be eerily silent. What, then, was he yamming about?

He craned his ear toward the voice coming in through the vents. The murmuring cleared quickly into discernible conversation, and with clarity, he identified the other speaker: the girl. Of course. They were having a back and forth, but there was no urgency or strain to their tone. His brow wrinkled: what could they be chatting about?

[*It's really not*.] Chewie softened the reply like he was

sensitive to not reprimand the girl. [*I don't get much of a chance to see many of the places we go. There's a lot of staying on the ship, and what I do see, I see from the cockpit*.]

"Always?"

[*Not, not always*] the Wook answered. [*But often*.]

A beat of quiet. "I'm sorry," she offered, her voice soft. "That sounds so…restrictive."

Chewie chuckled in a low snort. [*It's an improvement from where I was*.]

"That, I don't doubt." She paused again. "What about home? Can you tell me about home?"

At this, the Wook rumbled with distinct melancholy. [*I miss home. I've been gone a long time*.]

"Do you have the ability to stay in contact at all? Do you know who's still there?"

Chewie warbled, and Han could picture the bulbous, hairy head tossing side to side in thought. [*It's hard to send messages. The blockade keeps a lynchline around everything coming and leaving the planet. I'm lucky if I can get something through once every few months, and sometimes it takes half a year to hear anything back*.]

"The Imperials are real bastards." She said that low and with a barely restrained vitriol. "It's awful what they do to your people."

The Wook let go of a soft trill. The conversation then paused, like a respectful moment of silence, before Chewie started again. [*But I know my father is still there*.]

"What's your father like?" she asked, her voice couched in that warm, evocative softness.

[*My father is a chieftain in our area. In his heyday, he was a powerful leader. Very good at managing disputes, letting honor and custom prevail over egoism and petty squabbles. Restrained, but protective, if need be*.]

"I see in that regard, you take after him," she replied, and even through the vent, Han could hear the smile in her voice.

[*He wouldn't say that*.] Chewie chuckled. [*My father's*

complaint about me was that I was too restless. Too brazen.]

"*Bold?* That's not a word I would use for you."

[*In my younger years*] the Wook clarified, perhaps a sheepishness to his tone. [*But time has a tendency to file our rough edges. I wasn't rambunctious and showed nothing but deference to my father and our traditions, but…I did like to venture out.*]

"Away?"

[*Sometimes, but that wasn't the issue.*] the Wook answered. [*See, on Kashyyyk, the forest is broken up into layers–*]

"You were a pathfinder?!"

Chewie went quiet for a beat. [*You know what that is?*]

"Uh, my understanding is that there are some who venture out into unsettled parts of the forest to lay way for further expansion. At least, that's true for the arboreal Wookieetribes. You *are* arboreal, right? I didn't mishear your accent?"

The Wook barked a laugh. [*That's right! I'm from a region north of Rwookrrorro, the capital. It's all wyroshr trees there.*]

"I remember my learning materials talking about your infrastructure, how you build your homes inside the trees. I was awed at that. I couldn't fathom anything that large."

Chewie chirped, matching her tone. [*Big and wide as the high rise we landed on on Esseles! Whole cities of people make homes inside them. Communities, like our tribe. But, to your question, no, I wasn't a pathfinder. I had a tendency to like to go down. All the way down. Few others visit the forest floor on Kashyyyk. Not without ceremony.*]

The girl hummed in recognition. "Yes, I remember reading about that, too. How the forest floor is a separate ecosystem from the canopy. The Shadowlands, right?" Chewie chirped an affirmative at her, then she said nothing for a beat. "It's funny, now that we're talking about it–it reminds me of the Lower Levels on Nar Shaddaa. Have you been down there?"

[*I haven't. What's there?*]

"Depends on who you ask. The answer might be criminals.

Some would say the deranged. It might be mutated creatures that don't exist higher up. It might be ghosts. The Nar Shaddese are a very spiritual people; most couldn't give you a straight answer because it's too disrespectful to go down there. Or…*brazen*." She tittered at her reference. "But I do know one thing: it stinks. If you think the surface smells bad, it's intolerable below Level Three."

[*That could be reason enough to keep me away*.]

"There's nothing worthwhile down there anyway," she retorted casually. "What's down in the Shadowlands?"

[*The forest floor is a wild place. Separate ecosystem, like you said. Different creatures, plants, fungi. There was no shortage of territory to find, life to discover, predators to fight off. It felt boundless*.]

"And the canopy had no such adventure for you?"

[*The Living Layer is its own world. I liked it up there, too. There's something that suffuses the air up there. More oxygen, yes, but something else. Something intangible. It's restorative. Connecting. On the forest floor, you feel alone. Up in the Living Layer, you are connected to every creature, every specimen. Every soul that ever lived*.]

"That sounds beautiful," she breathed.

The Wookiee was quiet a moment. [*It was*] he lamented.

At hearing Chewie's dolour, Han's chin dropped. He too had been told about the soaring trees, about waking up amongst the canopy and seeing unrestrained forest all the way to the horizon. The vastness in those stories had mesmerized him. But now? The Occupation had changed everything.

Her next question came out small, eked out, like managing her volume could manage the weight of the query. "Do you ever think about going back? Is it even possible?"

Chewie grunted before going quiet. [*My intention has always been to go back*] he eventually answered, [*to figure out a way. Or to help, somehow, from the outside. And I miss my father*.] He hesitated again, then let go of an adorable, submissive chirp. [*There is*

also a female there.]

The girl giggled knowingly. "What's her name?" she asked, drawing out the question in playful tease.

[*Mallatobuck. Malla. We were mates before I departed from Kashyyyk. I meant to return right away, but…*] Again, a moment of pregnant pause. [*At some point in the near future, I would like to go back to Kashyyyk to propose marriage to her.*]

"That's very romantic," she purred. "But…Captain Solo?"

At hearing his name, Han went tense. He strained to miss none of what was said next.

[*What about him*?] the Wookiee asked. Though perhaps Chewie had tried to suppress it, Han still picked up the tinge of sneer in the question.

"Forgive me if I'm misunderstanding, but the life debt means you're attached to him, yes? Are you going back *with* him? After? Is there an after?"

[*Not with.*] Another low growl emanated from Chewie. [*I hoped for some time that he would understand. Maybe be grateful and indulge me. I don't believe that anymore. He is self-serving and unapologetic. No, I'll have to find my way back on my own. After.*]

[*After.*] The word slipped into Han's skull, maybe through the crack at his hairline, then bounced around until it swirled and found its way down his spine. It sank into his belly, sucking his ribcage in tighter. After. [*On my own.*] After.

Again, the Wookiee manifested in his doorway, shaking with rage, the words spitting out past bared teeth. The exact words of the curse, laid out in poetic Wookiee prose like the dangerous yet sacred condemnation Chewie willed them to be, Han couldn't remember, but he recognized the sentiment. The feral, blinding urge to strike out against the insidious. And yet, behind that, still in those deep blue eyes despite the contempt: disappointment. The expectation, maybe the wish, that Han could or should be better and had fallen short. Grateful. Chewie hoped he might be grateful.

At a choking in his throat, Han shot upright, coughing against

the constraint. He thumped on his chest, feeling like he'd swallowed something sideways. The urgency of the sensation dissipated with his efforts, though he still noticed tension in his jaw and flexed a grin to loosen it. Tentatively, he attempted again to swallow, and grimaced to still sense a soreness right underneath his chin. No, he discerned, it went lower than that. It gripped him all the way to his gut.

Annoyed, he took stock of himself, then checked again the time. Twenty minutes. He exhaled, disgusted–fuck it, he might as well just get up. He shifted, managing to pull himself to his feet despite an extra weight to his core. He still had his boots on, he realized, as they cushioned against the sharp gridlines of the floor. The 'fresher, he resolved faintly. 'Fresher first, then cockpit.

No overhead lights, he decided as he entered, instead leaving the door half cocked. He relieved himself, expecting some of the pressure at his abdomen to subside, but even as he finished, that fullness still reached up into his diaphragm. He took a squirt of sanitizer and worked it through his hands, keeping his shoulder turned away from the mirror. He didn't want to see. Surely, it could wait. But his ribs still ached, and his attention zoomed to the throbbing at his temple that suddenly shouted to be acknowledged. His fingers again delicately traced the outline, then he hissed at the alcohol sting of the sani on his wound. He caved, turning square to the mirror.

It looked pretty gnarly. Probably worse than it actually was, but the bruising had reached down toward his eye, giving him a shadow at the corner that resembled the markings on a Frillian viper. Kinda cool, if it had a better story behind it. Bacta would help, he thought again, then rifled through the medicine chest until he found a single-use salve. He applied it, giving the bruise a coating of off-white that masked the intensity of blues and purples. It'd be green in a few hours. Almost gone in a day.

He stood tall, assessing himself in full. He looked different than in his mind's eye, he realized. The sharp angles of his youth had already started to give way to the fullness of his age; the hair fell

across his brow instead of the trim cut he'd long worn at his forehead and temples. There was a tiredness, too, that he didn't remember. Maybe it was just from the trip, though. He couldn't remember anything being quite this rough…

Flashes of memory across his eyes blurred his reflection: Chewie skulking at him in the cockpit. The dark silence in the backseat of the airspeeder. The hot anger of the Imperial officer once they'd both clamored to their feet and fully regarded one another. Holding his ID after all this time, his thumb running over his name in blocky, raised script. And beside it, his rank. That damn title in front of his name had once meant so much to him. Not for what it was, per se, but for what it could be. What he couldn't wait to make someday.

His throat choked up again, and he cleared it a few times to no avail, then flicked on the faucet and sloshed mouthfuls of water to his lips. What little made it into his mouth, he swallowed down, but it offered no relief. Frustrated, he sank over the basin, one arm propping him up while the water still ran, the white noise the only defense he could muster. Again, his belly ached, churning with something, a bitter, sharp liquid that punched up toward his throat. He grimaced against it, willing the memory back down. He didn't *have* to remember, he tried to argue with himself. It's not like he forgot. Not really. But it could just…stay back down there, couldn't it?!

In the rumbling of the water, Chewie's furor came back to him. The bitterness. The disappointment. His anguish at having sworn the life debt at all.

Han had been a pilot–an officer. Top graduate at the Academy. Coming to the Outer Rim was a choice he had made, a place where he'd finally get the opportunity to prove himself and his skill. He'd transferred out expecting combat missions and assaults and defensive positions. Military engagement, since that's what they'd trained him for.

Prisoner loading was *not* what he transferred out for. It was grunt work. It was beneath him. At least, that was his initial reaction

at receiving his orders–indigance at being asked to do something so annoyingly routine. What a gut punch it had been to find out *who* he was in charge of transporting. Salt in the wound.

No, that didn't quite cover it; salt stung, but it didn't corrode all the way down. It didn't rip open a wound that otherwise might have healed over. He felt stunned, almost to the point of unbelieving, to learn that the Empire–despite its boastful speeches about freedom and justice–trafficked in slaves, and to see chain gangs of Wookiees on top of it. The whole business felt contemptible. It *was* contemptible. And, despite an initial urge to forget, to convince himself he was mistaken, to try and find some other explanation to justify it, it was *real*, and he was a part of it.

He debated for a while what to do. Tried to slip his way out of those orders, to get himself reassigned, even if temporarily, to some other job or some other place. Yet the machine would not budge for him. Wouldn't make room or accommodation on principle. The rigidity and callousness rubbed him raw. And then, to hold an electric disruptor in his hand and listen to his superior scream at him to follow orders to thrash a rebellious Wookiee, to look up into the dewy, deep eyes in that russet coat and see the haunting reminder of the only person who'd ever cared for him…everything in the immediate aftermath was a series of unconscious movements. It was the same as when he got in the pilot's seat, and his hands gripped the yoke: he became part of the ship, not unthinking as much as intuiting everything, all of his limbs responding before his consciousness could even register the cannon fire or the asteroid or the tractor beam.

He'd only really regained the full sense of what he'd done when the cell door had closed on him. His senses started with the space around him: the dark, the cold, the solitude. Everything was sharp edges of gray; even the bench provided lacked any sort of cushioning, any measly attempt at comfort.

He'd held his head in hands as he recapped as best he could. The memories were a flurry of images and a cacophony of sounds. The Lieutenant Commander's interrupted yelp upon contact with the

spark of the disruptor had nearly washed out under the howls of the Wookiees. Alarms calls went off, sirening in additional support, and the action around him happened in flashes of red. Towering figures jostled him until he'd lost his balance and ended up on the floor, curling into a ball to protect against the churning stampede. He remembered his name being shouted, over and over again, and then hands had been on him, forcing him to stand. A stun had mostly missed him but managed to hit his legs, and down he'd almost gone again, save for the grips at both his armpits. The floor had moved underneath him as his head dipped, but his feet were not what was carrying him forward.

By the time his trial had started, he'd already made up his mind: he would not feel a lick sorry for what he'd done. Let them throw him in jail; he'd take it. But they'd get no confession nor contrition. How easy it was for him, then, to stare deadpan off into space during examination. His lips moved with the same phrase at each prompt: "I decline to answer." Maybe as a result, since it was then difficult to prove his purpose–to hang him by his own words–or maybe because they didn't want any additional undue attention on the situation, his prosecutors had declined to pursue criminal punishment. Expulsion, in their eyes, would provide penalty enough, a stain that he would carry on his back forever.

He'd held it together up until that point, withstanding every alternating threat and lecture with indifferent eyes and a set jaw. But his final dressing down, watching his insignia and name get ripped from his uniform, having his CO spit venom in his face, castigating him…that had taken effort to remain there seemingly unmoved. He could withstand being told he was an asshole and a hothead and an idiot, he'd had a lifetime of that. But to be told he was a disappointment…his chin had wavered then.

Han picked his head up with a gasp, emerging from memory to realize he'd been holding his breath. Too hurriedly, he stood up. His head swam and his vision grayed out. He braced himself on the sink until the dizziness subsided, then blinked hard in the darkness of

the half-lit 'fresher.

The water–he'd left the faucet running. He swiftly shut it off, then grabbed at a towel and roughly mopped the water dripping off his chin and running down his neck. Tossing the towel back, he chucked the salve's empty container in the compactor before he slipped from the bathroom.

In the corridor, he could hear again the back and forth of conversation from the lounge. They had prattled onto something else that sounded more light and pleasurable. He heard the girl laugh, a throaty chuckle. His stomach turned at the sound, and he swiftly exited to the cockpit.

Inside, the stars streaked by in long, skinny bolts of light. The timer on his console read less than ten minutes. Exiting hyperspace required timing it just correctly; any less and the best outcome would be that they popped out much too far from the portal. Too much and they'd launch headfirst into a star. He'd just have to wait.

He settled into his chair, hands automatically reaching for his gloves. He slowed as he grasped them, though, aware it was too early. Instead, he laid them across a thigh, then sat back, swiveling slightly in his seat. His eyes glazed the cockpit, lazily searching for something that might hold his attention, give him a task, keep him busy. Half-heartedly, his thumbnail picked at something on his armrest he imagined might be dirt but proved to be only a stain. The exaggerated breath that left him blew the hair around his brow, the locks dancing in his peripheral vision.

He resumed spinning in the chair, chewing at his lips as his eyes met again the swirling blue-white of hyperspace. Some part of him alerted that it was bad to stare, that hyperspace hypnosis was a real, dangerous risk and he should look away, but he argued back. It would only be a few minutes that he had to sit here. If nothing else, the alarm would stir him before he fell too deep.

His thoughts drifted to what waited for him on the other side of the portal. The payday, finally. What a faint light at the end of an increasingly imposing tunnel. He'd get his money, and then he could

do whatever he wanted with it. More repairs and improvements. More labor. More work. He'd expected, for how long he'd waited for something like exactly this, to feel good. Like, relieved. Excited. Maybe proud? Instead, as he twisted in his seat, he felt…not nothing, exactly, but like something gnawed at him. A discomfort.

'I get it now, why the Hutts insisted it be you' the girl had said, gazing at him with an uncanny gentleness. An undeserved sympathy. '*Who better to free a slave than someone who already has?*'

That's not what happened, he heard himself argue back, an echoing that fell away before the echo could finish. Had he said that to her?

'*I never asked you to come find me!*'

The Imps had expelled him at their next port of call. Dishonorable discharge. He had never felt so untethered as he had upon exiting the *Predator*. Naked, too–the only possessions he'd been allowed to retain were the already worn boots and the pants with the bloodstripe down the side.

The first thing he did was replace the stiff prisoner's button down with a tunic and utility vest. He then skipped two sectors over–anything to be away from them–and the next thing he found was a tavern. Only in alcohol could he drown out his misery. He didn't want to remember anything that had happened, didn't want to think about what he was going to do next, didn't want to even remember his name. He didn't rouse trouble, and the bar staff largely took pity on him, some of them even trying to help him sober up and talk about what had happened. Alternating between silence and sarcasm, he tipped generously to keep them from putting him out entirely.

Sometimes, though, the memories did seep in. He had replayed what he could remember of that last fateful day, over time increasingly unsure how much of it was memory and how much had been manufactured. He hadn't caught the name of the slave he was supposed to discipline nor did he think he could recall the details of his face or fur, but those blue eyes that approached him in the bar all

of three months later could have belonged to no one else.

Despite every attempt at driving him away–going silent, avoiding him, barking at him, downplaying what had happened, insisting the Wook had misunderstood–Chewie had not wavered. Instead, he stuck it out, bearing Han's outbursts and tantrums and muteness without recoil. He remained faithfully at Han's side, intimidating anyone who approached from bothering either of them.

[*After all we've been through.*]

It was Chewie who had pestered him into pulling himself together. He pushed Han into thinking about what was next. To *have* a next. Eventually, in stops and starts of sobriety, the idea came together: contact Mako, who'd ventured out into the unknown years before. He knew what it was to get cut off from everything; he'd know how to make a life post-Empire. Find work. Get a ship. Make a new life. Survive.

Survive.

Han seemed to remember something and blinked. His tunnel vision waned. He took stock of his surroundings. The cockpit. Hyperspace. Almost time to decelerate.

Uneasy, he shifted himself in his seat. The gloves flopped around in his lap, and he managed to snatch them before they fell to the ground, then started to slip them on. He moved slowly, methodically, strangely aware of the texture of the leather against his knuckles. He put his body into position, anticipating the announcement of the hyperspace exit. And at the edges of his vision, he picked out the empty copilot seat.

He slackened. He could exit hyperspace without Chewie–he'd done it plenty of times. But the rest of it…this trip and the circuit board, the diagnosing, and the parts number, and the install. The trips that had come before–the amount of times Chewie's knowledge and strength and resolve had fixed a problem. Could Han have done that alone? Maybe. But–his lips tucked under as he conceded–it would have been a lot *harder* without him.

At that, something swirled in Han's chest, high enough near

the skin that he could finally recognize it: guilt. Guilt about…well, *a lot* of it. About lying. About pushing him off. Dismissing him. About…about not being grateful.

His mouth twisted to really feel the discomfort spread across his breast and over his shoulders. In an eagerness to dispel it, his brain started whirling. The trip was near over, he reasoned. They'd be back, and they'd get busy, and things could reset. And maybe…maybe he could be a little nicer. More agreeable. Maybe not quite so…so snippy. He usually could hear it after the fact, that he'd been harsh. Maybe he could catch himself faster. Be a little more even-keeled, even when things went sideways. Things would break–that seemed inevitable. Maybe, he waxed, that's just what life out here was like. Maybe he could figure out how to make peace with that.

And then it struck him–not hard, not like a revelation, but like something just outside his reach. Lots of things could be different. *Were* different. Coming out of hyperspace, landing, getting the payment for this trip at last. He'd had a few instances in his life of crossing a barrier, a point of no return, into which he could divide the chapters of his life. He glanced out again at the swirl of the white and blue before him. Perhaps, he mused, this was one of them.

The alarm sounded, jarring him. His hands flew out to silence it, then moved to the controls for the hyperdrive. He held his breath, then dropped the lever.

Space emerged before him. In the distance sat the little blue ball with the brown world beyond it.

Footfalls clambered toward the cockpit then halted at the bulkhead. [*I didn't realize you were up*.]

"Yeah," Han returned quietly, his eyes forward. "You seemed like you were busy."

Silently, the Wook stooped through the threshold and took his seat. Headset on, he promptly busied himself in screens. [*Lots of traffic*.]

Indeed, in the shimmer of reflective glints from the nearby star, Han could pick out that the starfield was littered in spacecraft.

“Anything to worry about?”

[*Not that I can tell*] Chewie answered, a stiff, almost nettled shade over his voice.

Han shifted slightly in his seat, shooting a furtive glance over at his copilot. Yeah, the Wook was still mad. “So,” he started sheepishly, “what did you guys talk about?”

Chewie took too long to study a systems readout. [*She offered that you may have misunderstood*] he answered, cool. [*That the Huttese word for her position has multiple meanings.*]

A barely perceptible loosening rippled in Han’s chest. “I told you I didn’t know.”

[*I heard what you said.*]

The retort had come out sharp, a drawing of a curtain. What followed after came only brooding silence, a dare for Han to try again to break it.

Han played along. He busied himself with navigating the field, moving them perhaps needlessly far from a convoy before putting them back on course. After some time, though, the silence felt oppressive. Choking. He glanced at Chewie, sensing the temperature had gone down enough to try again.

He cleared his throat. “I did hear the tailend of what you were saying. You have family on Kashyyyk?”

Chewie turned to stare at him hard. [*I do.*]

“Oh,” Han replied. His head cocked. “Is that where your money goes?”

[*Is everything with you about money*?] the Wookieesnapped.

“No,” Han rebutted in a slight plea, “I just…it makes a lot make sense.” He went silent again, curious if Chewie would follow up. He did not. “Uh, well…how come you never said any of that to me?”

[*You never asked*] Chewie answered, quick and cold. He prepped the request for ATC.

A shade fell over Han’s brow at the sneer. He wilted in his seat, the small of his back just touching his chair before the contact registered. He made himself sit up, sit forward, and concentrate fully

out the view window. Distantly, he heard ATC answer the request; he reported out their destination and acknowledged his clearance.

Breaking atmosphere and swooping carefully down toward the surface, navigating the traffic heading up and away, ditching the smoke stacks of the industrial sector–all of it was welcome distraction. They flew through the chute that led to the Spacebarn, its cavernous width empty save for the little *Starmite*, and then Han flew his ship to hover over Bay 7. He made their final descent slow, easy, resting the weight of the vessel on her legs as gently as he could.

Post-flight checks had their own procedures. The copilot had his sensors and readouts to make sense of, including to command the main computer to complete a full report of systems, while Han filed the final logs for the completed trip. He checked fuel levels, eyeballed his weapons outfit, assessed water quantity–all items he might need to refill before their next take-off.

And then at some point, all the tasks were complete, and he took himself off autopilot. He sank back down into his body, assessing his own needs, his own discomforts. He frowned to find that things still sat awkward in his torso. It was like something was wedged in his ribs. He expected–wished–it maybe would have worked its way out by now.

Chewie was finishing up. Once he'd finished reading the analysis from the main computer, he'd take off his headphones and then get up from his seat. He'd go to his bunkroom first before he left and grab his satchel and maybe also whatever little tinkering project he was working on, and then he'd be ready to head back to the apartment. Or he'd hang around the Spacebarn, offer himself up to Shug.

He'd never said anything about Dewlanna to Chewie, Han realized as he watched the Wook. Chewie didn't know why Han did what he did. If he knew, knew all of it…maybe he'd get why it was all so hard. He sighed, a fullness in his throat that he needed to either eject or swallow back down.

[*I'm going to grab the stimm tea and head off*] Chewie said

without looking at him.

Han wheezed. “You're *leaving*?!”

The Wook turned slightly in his seat, hands coming up to remove his headset. [*I'll be frank: I don't really want to be around you right now*.]

Words, noise–any kind of response–eluded Han. As Chewie started to get up, though, he blurted the only thing he could think. “Do you want help?”

[*No*] the Wook answered curtly. He moved deftly through the small cockpit like he was in a hurry, but then stopped himself just before putting a foot out the bulkhead. [*But you had better make amends with her if you'd like to stay gainfully employed*.]

Chewie exited with no additional feedback or instruction or goodbye. Han remained in his seat, a heat at the back of his neck, listening as the Wook followed his routine. Footsteps went to his bunkroom. He passed through the lounge, said some words to the girl, and then Han heard the initial unlock of the cargo bay. The mechanism droned as it dropped to the floor, a screeching in the gears that they’d both been meaning to oil, followed by the footfalls of his exit to the gangplank. The ship opened, and then Han saw only the top of the Wookiee’s head as he maneuvered in the bay, finding a pallet mover and finagling to get the block of stimm loaded. Alone, Chewie disappeared into the hangar corridor with the tea.

The ship fell quiet. Han took stock of himself, realizing he still wore his gloves. Slowly, distracted, he peeled them off. The palms were slightly wet, which he frowned at–he’d barely done any flying–but he draped them in such a way to let them air out. He did one last visual sweep of the space, trying to find something else to busy himself with.

Finding nothing, he huffed; he accepted he had to, but he didn’t want to go out there. Faintly, in his mind’s eye, he recalled that withdrawn look in her eyes at his last words, the glisten that he could recognize now was a tear. Make amends, indeed.

He could see her almost as soon as he came to the cockpit bulkhead. She was standing in the middle of the lounge, her bags all at her feet, her eyes emptily staring at some corner of the room. He hesitated a moment, unsure of exactly what to do, then took the next few steps to cross into the lounge.

Her eyes flickered up to catch his, though they darted back to the floor for a fleeting second before she lifted her chin. In her hand, she clutched her pink droid, and gestured with it. "Larsen will be here shortly," she offered, a distinct softness in her voice. Perhaps even, if she were capable, meekness. "He's coming by to pick me up, so you don't have to worry about walking me back."

"Oh," he returned after an awkward pause, suddenly overly aware of how he stood and the tone in his voice. "Uh, that's good–I mean, good for you."

"Jiliac has requested a debrief with me first, then they'll release your payment. I'm not scheduled to see him until tomorrow morning, so maybe wait until tomorrow afternoon before you head over."

His chin wrinkled. "S'good to know."

She nodded tightly, then turned down to her device.

He could feel the gap between them but didn't know how to navigate it. Quietly, he cleared his throat, hoping that the words would come. Nothing did, and instead, he surreptitiously studied her. In doing so, he took in details that he had been too rushed to notice before: the fine hairs around her ears and at her neck; the definition of her collarbone; the sharp lines of her top lip. In her black clothing–it was always black, wasn't it?–she had an artful curve from her shoulder to her waist down to her hip. That she was a dancer, with the athlete-artist's build, finally registered.

"Uh, I never thanked you…for getting that part for me," he finally offered, straining–perhaps too hard–to make his authenticity clear. He put his hands on his hips, then felt acutely aware of how stern that made him appear, and dropped them. "That was a really big help."

She listened, plain faced, holding his gaze. Only after a hesitation did she manage a polite smile. "No problem."

His head tilted, and his question came out small. "How…how did you get him to drop the price?"

She eyed him again, considering how–if–to answer. "There was a coupon he found," she finally explained. "You shouldn't have qualified–it was for returning customers–but he wanted to be helpful."

"Oh," Han remarked, nodding. "I, uh…I'll keep that in mind. About being pleasant."

She stared. She did not answer him.

He couldn't give up. He sucked in a breath, forcing a smile. "Ten months, yeah?"

This surprised her, as evident in the minor lift to her brows and enough to stilt her response. "I certainly would like to stick to that timeline," she responded, still dry. She looked at him a beat too long. "And what about you, Captain Solo?"

"Well, once I…" he choked a little on the words, "once I pick up my money, I'll put it to good use, and then, yeah–next job."

She softened slightly, a small, wry smirk at her lips. "I certainly appreciate the hustle."

"Chewie said you told him I didn't know," he blurted out, followed by a shrug. "That was…nice."

Guardly, she watched him. "It's accurate," she answered quietly. "Chewie explained to me that you'd laid out your boundaries from the start. The Hutts were obscure on purpose; they weren't going to be honest with you and were betting you wouldn't pry."

His mouth pursed first. "I wouldn't have agreed to this if I'd known. I did ask."

"I believe you," she responded, bright but in a way that he could hear her choosing to be bright in a way that made it ring false. Her head cocked. "Congratulations, by the way."

"Congratulations?" He shrugged. "For what?"

"You've also made it through their trial. The Hutts elevate those they think they can trust."

Again, his lips pursed. He shifted, trying to get her praise to slide off his shoulders. "What would have happened to me…if you'd not come back? Blacklisted?"

She studied him again. "If they were feeling generous. Jiliac likes me, but I *am* property. I have material value, both real and potential. If you, an offworlder, lost them their investment, they'd extract it from you one way or another. I know more than one *woikeis* in debt bondage."

"Oh," he started, a hollowness in his throat. "Well, I'll try to never owe them money." He tried to say it lightly like a joke. He heard how flat it landed.

"Yeah, I'd advise against that." She paused again, assessing him. "Listen, before we go back out there–don't let them know that you know. About any of it. The Hutts play games *all* the time. They're good at it. Don't let them know you're smart."

"Uh, thanks," was the only response he could muster.

She smiled softly at him, then brought her attention back down to the pink puck in her hand.

He shifted his weight around, his tongue massaging at his bottom lip. He still felt he had to salvage this somehow. Sighing, his head dropped, and he stared down at his boots.

The courage came from somewhere in him: "Why did you come back?"

Immediately, the light left her face. "What?" she asked, taut.

She'd heard him, he knew, so he clarified. "You had a chance to run on Esseles. Open door, more than once. Why didn't you take it?"

He stared at her in earnest, but she didn't budge. Her stature had frozen in place, her expression inscrutable.

"I have my theater here," she eventually answered, still with a cautious timidity, a calculated diplomacy.

He gawked at her. "You didn't come back *for* the theater. You

could do that anywhere."

"*You* came back," she countered, a knowing lilt in her voice. "They lied to your face. Compromised you, and you came back. Can't you do this anywhere?"

He pondered her supposition. "Yeah–obviously. But that's not the same." His head cocked. "What, are you trying to say you like it here?"

Her answer came out clipped. "No. But what was I supposed to do instead?"

"You could have gone *anywhere*," he retorted. "Hopped on a cruiser and skipped down any arm of the galaxy that made you happy. What is it?" he continued. "You needed to come back here–you expect someone to come for you?"

She pulled in slightly but kept her composure. "There's no one to come for me."

He cooled. He recognized that withdrawal, the setting of her upper lip. "Then you have something set up here." Only in that moment did he hear himself, and swiftly put up hands. "Look, I ain't pryin' for dirt. I ain't a snitch. But it just doesn't make any sense."

"What doesn't make sen-?"

"That you'd come back!" he exclaimed, gesturing behind him at the gangplank. "Why not bolt?!"

She smiled, but he'd swear he saw a tinge of sadness in her eyes. "I wouldn't be so stupid. Hutts don't like when things are taken from them, Captain Solo; Jiliac wouldn't respond very well."

"You think they'd track you down?"

"I don't think, I *know*." She sighed, forcing her shoulders to drop back down. "Jiliac has spent a lot of money already on this venture. He means to see this investment bear fruit. I told you, I was being tested. But tested doesn't mean they don't have safety mechanisms in place."

Han's skin prickled at 'safety mechanism,' fully aware of her implication. "But still," he said. "You could *try*. It's possible to stay one step ahead of a bounty hunter."

She eyed him skeptically. “Where's the line between cocky and confident, Captain Solo?”

“Hey, I speak from experience,” he explained, drawing himself up. “No one's managed to catch me so far. You’re smart. You could pull it off–lay low, keep your head down.”

She heard him, but shook her head. “Yeah, but is that living or is it just staying alive?”

He balked at her answer. What was the difference, he questioned then wondered…did the difference even matter?

“Okay, fine,” he continued, emphatic. “The theater helps you how?”

At that, she fidgeted, a finger brushing at nothing on her cheek before she lifted her chin. “This theater is a means to an end.”

“What does that mean?”

She shrugged first, like the answer was obvious. “It’s the only way for me to move up.”

“Move *up*?” He squinted at her, confused.

She paused, stuck in her own bafflement, then receded slightly in understanding. “You keep looking down,” she started, her brow arched, “like the only *woikeis* are entertainers and floor washers. You need to look up, too. The whole Palace infrastructure is bonded, Captain Solo. It comes with restrictions and no rights, but it also comes with privileges. Look at Deino–*woikeis* and all that power.”

He stumbled over that. “*Deino?!*”

“All of us,” she reiterated. “Me, Larsen, Deino. The Hutts are too greedy and too cautious; they won’t share power with anyone without there being some kind of a catch or a ceiling.”

His mouth twisted. “I wouldn’t be able to tell,” he started, confused. “I mean, I don’t hear anybody talk about it. You didn’t–”

“It’s everywhere here,” she interjected. “Invisible, if you don’t know what you’re looking for, but everywhere. And nobody talks about it because it’s normal. It’s the way things are done. People come into it and sometimes even, people get out. That’s what all of us are hoping for, and the only way to get that is to stay in line. And the

Nar Shaddese," she shrugged, accepting. "The Hutts only use off-worlders; why would the locals say anything? They have enough trouble with the Desilijic as it is."

He went quiet as he processed that. He wondered what Salla would say. Would she listen? Would she care? Or was that the point, the division the Hutts could use to their advantage to exploit two different groups at once. His brows raised: they *were* smart.

He picked his head up to see her half-watching him. "So you want Deino's position?"

She shook her head. "No. No, I need something else." Her head dropped for a breath, and in doing so, he could see the burden she carried, how heavily it pressed on her crown, her shoulders…and how gracefully she carried it as she lifted her chin again. "I'll be frank with you: I want away from them. I want off Nar Shaddaa. But the only way *out* of this for me is *through*."

"Through to what? How?"

Her eyes shifted off to the corner, the depth in her gaze testament to the weight of the question. Reluctantly, she brought herself back, her shoulder limply shrugging. "I don't know yet. But the more distance I can keep between myself and the Palace, the better. If I do a great job at this–and I mean to–then I'll get to stay away longer, and more possibilities will open up for me. After that, I'll…I'll figure it out."

He looked at her sideways. "That's such a risk."

She returned the expression. "What other choice do I have?"

His lips parted to answer…and then hung there, mute. No, he accepted, closing his mouth–she was right. There was no other choice, and the oppressiveness of her quandary left him speechless.

His eyes fell, his shoulders heavy. "I don't envy your position," he started slowly. "Sounds like you got dealt a real bad hand."

She stiffened at his acknowledgement, then inclined her head. "I'll be okay. Most people don't make it this long or this far, so," she took in a tight breath, a flicker of uncertainty shadowing her eyes, but

it disappeared with her quick exhale, “maybe I know what I’m doing.”

He winced. “Still. You’re putting an awful lot of effort into a ‘means to an end.’”

To his surprise, she huffed a laugh, like this was not the first time this criticism had been lobbed at her. She raised her brows, a smidge sheepish, maybe even bashful. “I don’t know how to do it any other way. I think if you’re gonna do something, do it right.” And then, somehow, while holding his gaze, she smiled. It was nothing big, just the tiniest curl to her lips and slight squint in her eyes, but dammit, if he didn’t grin back in return.

He regarded her again, a smidge bewildered, then finally surrendered to a laugh. “You know something? You’re all right. I thought you were gonna be somethin’ different, but you're not, you’re…” He couldn’t find the right word, so he let the sentiment hang in the air.

She smiled again, and this time, she did not have to think about it. “And you’re alright yourself, Captain Solo. For a pirate.”

He wagged a finger at her. “Smuggler,” he corrected, smiling wryly. “You gotta watch the words you use around us. Some of ‘em take a real hurtin’ to the label ‘pirate.’”

“Noted,” she said lightly with a subtle nod of her head. She glanced at the gangplank and her countenance shifted. “Whatever you said in the cockpit, but he didn't seem happy when he left.”

Han waved her off. “He’ll be fine. He's got his vow or whatever. He’ll cool off.”

She tilted her head. “You know, he does care for you. To anyone else who’d pissed him off that much, he would have *disassembled* them.”

The image of the pipe getting rent in two flickered in his mind’s eye. “It's just part of the life debt,” he insisted.

She was quiet a beat, then her voice came out delicate. “No, I don't think it is.”

“It’s…it’s whatever,” he started, frustration flaring again, though he took a breath and tempered it. In an attempt to be

lighthearted, he added, “And for the sake of accuracy, I *didn’t* free him.”

She pouted skeptically. “That’s not the way Chewie told the story.”

“He’s–” His lips folded over. Chewie must have said everything–the incident, his court martial and expulsion, all of it. “He’s embellishing.”

Those narrow eyes didn’t cease dissecting him. “Well, you did something to warrant his gratitude. I know that a life debt is not given haphazardly, and he’s honoring it truer than most.”

Han looked away, jaw tightening, doing his utmost not to think about it. Yet at the back of his brain, the thought was there, if faint: maybe she was right. Maybe that was worse.

He picked his head up to find her attention on him. She was making some kind of assessment, and then the corners of those dark eyes ever so slightly creased in humor.

“What’s so funny?” he goaded, uneasy but trying to hide it beneath a smarmy grin.

At that, the impishness in her face increased, the cheeks blushing to pink as her mouth twisted to the side, self-satisfied. “You deceive, Captain Solo,” she waxed. “An ex-Imperial? I wouldn't have guessed."

He coughed out a laugh. “I'll take that as a compliment,” he jockeyed.

She inclined her head ever so slightly. “It’s how it was meant.”

He shifted his weight, again trying to make her kindness slide off his shoulders. “Listen, don’t…don’t say anything about it, okay? Please.”

Her head cocked. “Why don't you want anyone to know?”

“People don't much like the Imperials around here.” Having said it, he lifted brows at her suggestively.

“True,” she returned, demure. “But you're not one anymore. It might even be a badge of honor to have screwed them over?”

He hesitated. “Not sure that's enough.”

In her hand, the comm chirped again. She made sense of a message, then gestured toward the gangplank. "He's here." She let him take the bulk of her luggage, then together, they descended.

Sure enough, just beyond the gangplank stood the thick-necked Larsen. He was probably in his forties, maybe his fifties, and though not taller than either himself or the girl, he was a solid brick of mass. Larsen's attention zeroed in on them, moving right past Han to confirm Korë's presence, and–if the pilot guessed correctly–her safety.

"We all good?" the guard questioned in a gruff voice, sizing Han up and down again before he scanned Korë for the third time.

"Of course," she answered in that cordial, disarming tone. "Back safe, one piece, all that."

Larsen tried to read her, skeptical, but Han was sure he couldn't make heads or tails of her posturing or the truth. Instead, the man extended a hand to the pilot. "The Palace sends their gratitude."

Han placed the bags down and accepted Larsen's greeting, then labored to keep a straight face as the guard crushed his fingers. "Don't mention it," he mustered. Finally getting his hand back, he gestured toward the far end of the Spacebarn. "I'll walk you guys out; that mall can get kinda maze-like."

Korë's hand brushed him off. "No need," she cooed. "I remember the way."

Han struggled to smother a wry grin as he remembered the intentness with which she had watched him as they'd entered. *So*, he mused, a mix of impressed and humored, *she* had *been paying attention*.

Meanwhile, Larsen had busied himself with gathering up Korë's luggage. He grabbed all of it in one armful, then stood and gawked at her, wordlessly trying to usher her on.

"I'm following," she said sweetly, ushering him to go ahead.

Larsen faltered, staring hard at her.

"I'll be right behind you," she coaxed, somehow matching Larsen's intensity but wrapping it in honey.

Once Larsen marched off, she turned back to Han, her visage

warm. “I’ll speak well of you to Jiliac. Thank you, Captain Solo, for the safe passage…and the conversation.” And then her gaze hung there on him, her expression marked not with glittering wit or sly charm, but something else. It took him a beat to recognize, but then it registered: sincerity.

He stared perhaps a second took long before he finally remembered himself. His head dipped, courteous. “It was my pleasure.” And, as she smiled again and began to turn away, he realized…it was.

She left. He remained there a beat, alone, then found himself drifting to the bay entrance to watch her walk down the corridor. She moved deliberately and unhurried, not walking so much as floating. He remembered then catching her in the theater, the graceful way she could hold her weight and move her arms. He half-wished he’d been able to see her dance.

He was still staring when he heard his name get called behind him. He turned to find Jarik at his elbow, the kid's eyes already trained down the corridor.

“Who is *that*?” the kid breathed, entranced.

Han chuckled dryly. “Out of your league, Kid. Out of everybody’s league. She’s Desilijic.”

That got Jarik's attention. The kid swung his gaze back to Han, and in doing so, took in the welt at his hairline. “What happened to you?” he asked, anxiety creeping into his voice.

Han sighed. “Long story.”

Jarik absorbed that, or tried to. His eyes drifted back down the corridor, then up again to Han. There his attention hovered, an apprehension apparent in the flatness of his mouth.

“What?” Han baited. “I didn’t come back with anything. Just stimm tea, but–” His mouth contorted. “Chewie already took care of it.”

The kid didn’t waver. Instead, his eyes were big, like he needed to say something but couldn't.

“What?” Han asked again, this time braced, catching now the

slight tremor in the boy's frame.

The kid's throat worked first to find the words. "I heard something. About you," Jarik eked out, then feebly swallowed in a vain attempt to bolster. It rather made his words creak out. "I heard you used to be in blue."

The hair across Han's body turned to needles. "Where'd you hear that?" he asked, quiet but tight.

"I overheard it," the kid mewled.

"From who?!" Han growled, closing on the kid. "Names, dammit!"

Jarik edged back, making space between them. "Some people around here. Couple people in the bazaar who know you."

Immediately, Han's head spun, trying to figure out who to blame. His eyes darted to the empty bay across from his. Mako apparently had already run his mouth to the Hutts. Wouldn't be inconceivable that he sputtered off to more people. Spince could be a spiteful shit, and *he'd* never been paid over four thousand for a job. But Spince had his own secrets. He wouldn't flinch in the standoff.

Deino? Possibly. But Deino always gave him the impression she held her cards close to her chest. A devious sabacc player, if she ever wanted to be one. She'd not just toss information like that out into the nether. She'd hold it over his head with purpose. Another thing of his to keep up her sleeve.

A certainty settled between his ribs before the idea fully formed. No, the Desilijic. *Had* to be. He'd passed their little test–of loyalty or greed or whatever metric they used–and now they wanted a monopoly on him. Wanted him beholden. Kept. The fuckers. Smart didn't quite cover it.

A prickle crawled between his shoulder blades. A faint sense of a target on his back. He did a hurried sweep of the bay and the hangar—catwalks, doorways, the shadowed ribs of the ceiling. Down the corridor, two people who otherwise looked embroiled in conversation noticed him. Both flickered eyes over his person, then darted them to the floor, their dialogue interrupted and difficult to

restart. One tapped the other at the shoulder and gestured they step into the nearest bay. Both tossed a fleeting glance at him again before they disappeared.

Han swallowed over the lump in his throat. Okay…so that's how it was going to be now.

"There's something else," Jarik said, his voice gone small again. He tried not to shrivel under Han's scrutinizing glare. "Some people tried to pressure Mr. Ninx to cut your bay access."

"*And?!*"

Jarik shrank but managed to sputter out an answer. "He pushed back."

Han loosened, letting go of a clipped snort. The mechanic knew the value of a credit. Or, possibly, he understood condemnation all too well.

He straightened and craned his neck to consider his ship. The red hull of the 'Suub shone dull in the lights of Bay 7. His next steps were clear: focus on what matters. On what he could control. He couldn't stop people from knowing now, and couldn't stop them from talking, and he couldn't make them understand or hear him out or not hold it against him. He was a smuggler for the Hutts–that's what he'd be known for. That was what he'd *make them* know him for.

"Shug anywhere around here?" Han asked, his eyes still locked on the 'Suub.

"Last I saw him, he was in Bay Twelve. Why?"

Han slipped a small coin from his pocket to his palm to Jarik's nimble fingers in a single, smooth movement as he answered. "Tell him I need to put an order in. A *big* one."